

LEARNING TO ASK INSTEAD OF DEMAND # 49

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the effects on others of different forms of expression.
2. Decrease the frequency of occurrence of angry thoughts, feelings, and behaviors.
3. Practice asking for things instead of demanding them in one relationship and evaluate the results.
4. Create a plan to adopt a respectful style of communication.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE OPPOSITIONAL DEFIANT BEHAVIOR

- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- Anger as a Drug
- Being Genuinely Unselfish
- Communication Skills
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Is My Anger Due to Feeling Threatened?
- Is My Anger Due to Unmet Expectations?
- Respect or Fear?

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Learning to Ask Instead of Demand” activity is designed for clients whose communication and relationship styles present as disrespectful or inconsiderate. Its approach is to examine reasons people may resist asking for what they want rather than demanding it, then shift to a pragmatic view with the aim of finding the communication style that will work best. It then asks the client to select a relationship on which to conduct a 1-week experiment with a more respectful style and report on the outcome. Follow-up for this exercise could include ongoing discussion with the counselor or treatment group on the impacts of communication styles in other relationships.

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Why should you work at learning to ask people for what you want from them instead of demanding it? The main reason is that it works better. Think about your own reactions to others. How do you feel when someone asks you to do something, as compared to when they tell you to do it? If you're like most people, you prefer to be asked. This is something that many of us haven't learned, and it can cause problems in our relationships.

1. One reason many people tend to tell others what to do, rather than request, is that they don't feel right asking, especially in relationships in which they feel others owe them respect. They may feel that it would make them look weak or unsure of themselves if they asked others for things rather than told them what to do. This may be due to family or cultural traditions, or other reasons. When you picture yourself asking someone to do something rather than telling him/her, what feelings does that bring up for you?

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2. Actually, some of the most powerful people in history have also been very polite to those around them. Famous leaders like Abraham Lincoln have been known for being courteous to everyone they talked with. Many people believe that truly strong people are more likely to be gentle because they don't need to prove their strength by pushing people around. Can you think of a strong person you know who is polite and considerate to others?

Would you like to have others think of you the same way you think of that person?

3. No matter how we feel about being respectful, to get what we want in our relationships we need to put our messages in whatever form will get the results we're looking for. This means we need to put ourselves in the other person's shoes and listen through his or her ears. Think about situations where someone has ordered you around—a parent or other family member, a boss, a teacher. Now imagine how you would have felt if they had asked you respectfully rather than just telling you what to do. Would you have felt better about it? _____

Would you have done what they wanted? _____ Would it have confused you about whether they were still "in charge"? _____

4. There is always more than one message in everything we say: one or more messages in our words and at least one message in the way we say something. When we ask others for things (e.g., simply saying "please," "thank you," "Would you . . ."), we're also giving this message: *I*

respect your feelings and your dignity and I am being polite to you because I care how you feel. When we leave these things out and simply order people around, we're giving this message: *Your feelings and dignity aren't important, and I don't have to be polite to you because I don't care how you feel.* You may actually care very much about the other person's feelings, but that is the message you may be sending without meaning to.

It might be useful to test this with an experiment. Do you have a relationship in which you're used to simply telling the other person what to do? _____ If so, who is that person? _____

Here's what we suggest: try switching the way you do things for a week and asking this person for what you want instead of demanding it. You might try telling him/her you're doing this experiment. You could explain that you're practicing a new way of communication to show that he/she is important to you, and that you're going to try asking for things instead of demanding them. You may forget and slip into the old way during the week. Habits are hard to break. You can ask him/her to remind you, and he or she can do that by asking you to rephrase what you're saying. How does it feel to picture yourself doing this?

5. If it works and this relationship gets better, will it be worth it? _____
6. After trying this experiment for 1 week, please describe the results here.

7. If you feel this experiment was worthwhile, please use this space to describe a plan to practice this more respectful approach to dealing with people in all your relationships.